MOUNTAIN OF THE MONTH

ALTA UTAH

By Jeff Foss

QUICK STATS

Trails: 50 **Lifts:** 12
Summit: 10,550 ft.
Base: 8,530 ft.
Total Vertical: 2,020 ft.
Skiable Terrain: 2,200 acres
Beginner: 25% **Intermediate:** 40%
Advanced: 35%
Avg. Annual Snowfall: 500 in.

Snowmaking: 50 acres
Lift Ticket:
Adult: $40
Season Pass:
Adult: $795
Flying There:
Salt Lake City Airport (35 minutes away)

Reservations: 888.782.9258
Snow Report: 801.359.1078
Web: www.alta.com

Contrary to what some people think, you don't need facial hair, boot gaiters, or an old, duct-taped jacket to tear it up at Alta. Nope, that's telemarking. What you need to ski Alta is an open mind, massive balls, and the knowledge that there's a reason this mountain doesn't have a terrain park or halfpipe. Utah has some of the sickest terrain in North America, and well, Alta has some of the sickest terrain in Utah.

Alta 101

Alta has a rugged history. A group of picnicking miners discovered **silver** there in **1864**, providing early settlers with the first-ever excuse to get away from Salt Lake City. Alta was destroyed by a **fire in 1878** and again by an **avalanche in 1885**, when the tiny mountain town was reportedly buried under **50 feet of snow**.

Plans to develop a ski resort at Alta began to take shape during the late **1930's**. When the **Collins Chair** opened in **1939** you could ski for just 25 cents a run, or pay $1.50 for an all-day ticket. In **1942** the **503rd Parachute Battalion** used Alta as its **winter warfare** training grounds before it headed off to **WWII**.

Skiers Only

Snowboarding is still prohibited at a few resorts in North America: **Alta**, **Taos**, and, **Deer Valley**. This **"Skiing Emphasis"** policy is said to create better parking, dining, lift lines, and terrain conditions. And yes, you can bet your ass this pisses off the riding community.

One-Two Punch

Alta and **Snowbird** have finally teamed up to offer a **combined lift pass**. For around **$25** extra, a price that includes the connecting **tram**, you can hit up both mountains on the same ticket. **"The Bird"** is much bigger than Alta in terms of area and is **snowboarder-friendly** as well, so you can at least spend part of the day waiting for any snowboarding buddies you might have.

Big Names in Little Cottonwood

With what the state has dubbed **"The Best Snow on Earth"**, Utah attracts its fair share of well-known rippers. A lot of these guys tear it up right here in Alta, including **Gordy Peifer** and **Jamie Pierre**. Other regulars include **Brant Moles**, **Jeremy Nobis**, **the Collins brothers**, **Sage Cattabriga**, **Dave McReynolds**, and **Dave "Gromet Comet" Richards**.

Salt Lake Shenanigans

Salt Lake City is world-renowned for its nightlife. No wait, that's Boston. There are a few notable hotspots in Salt Lake, however, such as **Golden Trails** and **Hog's Wallow**. **The Canyon Inn** is definitely where the party's at on Thursday nights. Since most of the city's population will frown upon the hangover you'll probably wake up with, remedy it quick with a burrito from **Lonestar**, a drive-through Mexican joint. Also check out the **Porcupine** for more delicious (and sinless) cuisine.

Sleepy Time

If daddy just handed you over $5,000 in cash and the keys to the Range Rover, then you'll have no choice but to stay at the **Alta Lodge** where you can virtually roll out of bed onto the hill. For the rest of us **ghetto bastards**, the best option is to pack the station wagon full of friends and chip in for a plush condo as close to the mountain as possible.

Bridging the Gaps

Unless you've been in a cave for the last two years you've probably seen pictures or footage of **Candide Thovex's historic D-spin** over **Chad's Gap**. This **90-foot monstrosity** happens to be located in the **Utah Backcountry**, right behind **Alta** and **Solitude**. You'll find such perversions as the **100-foot Pyramid Gap** and the insane **120-foot Leviathan Gap** here as well. These sacred stomping grounds are where some of freeskiing's biggest moments are captured on film.